

Module 4: Welfare and Rights Issues in Animal Agriculture: Part 1

Welfare Issues

Week 2 | Online-Synchronous | Friday

This session introduces animal welfare as a structured, evidence-based field concerned with the lived experiences of animals raised for food. Fellows will examine how welfare harms arise not primarily from isolated acts of cruelty, but from **routine, systematized practices** embedded in modern animal agriculture.

The session focuses on welfare—distinct from, but related to, animal rights—by examining established frameworks used globally to assess animals' physical and psychological well-being. Participants will be introduced to the **Five Freedoms** and the **Five Domains** as tools for understanding, evaluating, and communicating welfare conditions across different production systems.

Key Concepts and Frameworks

The Five Freedoms

The Five Freedoms framework articulates the minimum conditions required for acceptable animal welfare. It asserts that animals should have freedom from hunger and thirst; freedom from discomfort; freedom from pain, injury, and disease; freedom to express normal behavior; and freedom from fear and distress.

5 freedoms of animal welfare



[Figure 1: The 5 freedoms for animal welfare](#)

In this session, the Five Freedoms are used to help fellows identify where and how common animal agriculture practices—such as confinement, overcrowding, selective breeding, and routine mutilations—systematically violate multiple freedoms at once.

The Five Domains

The Five Domains framework expands on the Five Freedoms by emphasizing animals' **mental and emotional states**, not just physical conditions. It assesses welfare across four physical domains—nutrition, environment, health, and behavior—and links these directly to the fifth domain: mental state.



[Figure 2: The 5 domains model of animal welfare](#)

Participants will explore how welfare is cumulative and dynamic, and how chronic stress, frustration, and deprivation can persist even when animals appear outwardly “productive” or “healthy” by industry standards.

Resources

A. Foundational Welfare Frameworks (Global)

1. [World Organisation for Animal Health \(WOAH\) – Animal Welfare and the Five Freedoms](#)

This resource introduces the Five Freedoms as a foundational welfare framework recognized internationally. As you read, consider how these freedoms translate—or fail to translate—into real-world farming practices.

2. [Mellor, D. J. et al. – The Five Domains Model: Advancing Animal Welfare Assessment](#)

This paper explains the Five Domains framework and its emphasis on mental experiences. Focus on how welfare assessment moves beyond survival and productivity toward quality of life.

B. Welfare in Practice and Policy

1. [Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations – Animal Welfare and Livestock Production Systems](#)

This FAO resource discusses how animal welfare concerns intersect with livestock management, productivity, and sustainability. Reflect on how welfare is often framed as a technical issue rather than an ethical one.

2. [Animal Welfare Act \(RA 8485, as amended by RA 10631\): Provisions Relevant to Farmed Animals](#)

This Philippine reference allows you to examine how animal welfare is legally defined and limited in scope. As you read, consider which welfare dimensions are recognized, which are absent, and how enforcement affects animals' lived conditions.

C. Welfare Issues in Animal Farming

1. [Keley Kite, Faunalytics \(2019\) – Farm Animal Welfare: A Review of Standard Practices And Their Effects](#)

This review synthesizes evidence on how intensive farming practices affect both the physical and mental well-being of farmed animals. It examines common practices such as confinement, mutilations, early maternal separation, overcrowding, feed and water restriction, artificial lighting, and barren environments. As you read, focus on how welfare harms are systemic and how animals are forced to adapt to environments designed for efficiency rather than sentience. This resource is especially useful for applying the Five Domains framework, as it emphasizes mental states, coping capacity, and behavioral deprivation.

2. [FAIRR – Animal Welfare in Intensive Animal Agriculture](#)

This overview discusses how productivity-driven systems create chronic welfare harms, including stress, injury, behavioral deprivation, and early mortality. Reflect on how welfare outcomes are often considered acceptable as long as production targets are met.

Exercise – Applying the Five Domains Model to Animal Farming

This worksheet helps you apply the Five Domains Model to assess animal welfare in a specific farming context. The goal is not to produce a perfect or exhaustive evaluation, but to practice thinking systematically about animals' lived experiences—physically and mentally.

You may complete this worksheet individually or in small groups.

Step 1: Identify the Context

Animal Species	
Production system (e.g., intensive indoor, cage-based, crate-based, pasture-based, mixed)	
Life stage (e.g., breeding, growing, lactating, finishing)	
Country or context: (global / Philippine context if applicable)	

Step 2: Assess Each Domain

For each domain, briefly describe **conditions commonly experienced** by the animal in this system and how these conditions affect welfare.

Domain 1: Nutrition	Is access to food and water adequate in quantity and quality?
	Are feed or water restrictions common?
	How predictable or stressful is feeding?
	Notes:
Domain 2: Environment	What are the housing conditions (space, flooring, temperature, ventilation, lighting)?
	Are animals exposed to discomfort, extreme temperatures, or unsanitary conditions?
	Notes:
Domain 3: Health	What health problems are common (e.g., lameness, injuries, disease)?
	Are mutilations, selective breeding, or routine medical interventions involved?
	How are illness and injury typically managed?
	Notes:
Domain 4: Behavior	Can the animal express species-specific behaviors (e.g., nesting, rooting, grazing, social interaction)?
	Are animals confined, isolated, or repeatedly mixed with unfamiliar animals?

	Notes:
Domain 5: Mental State	What mental experiences are likely (e.g., stress, fear, frustration, boredom, comfort)?
	Are positive experiences possible, or is welfare largely defined by avoidance of harm?
	Notes:

Step 3: Reflection and Synthesis

Please respond briefly to the following:

1. Which domain appears most compromised in this system, and why?
2. How do limitations in one domain (e.g., environment) affect others (e.g., behavior or mental state)?
3. Which welfare harms seem structural rather than accidental or isolated?
4. Based on this assessment, do you think this system can realistically provide good welfare without major changes? Why or why not?

Optional Extension

If welfare improvements were introduced:

- Which domain should be prioritized first for meaningful impact?
- Would improving this domain require small adjustments or systemic change?

Reminder: The Five Domains Model emphasizes that welfare is cumulative and experienced subjectively by animals. Productivity or survival alone does not indicate good welfare.

Positioning for the Next Module

This session focuses on welfare as it is currently understood and operationalized. In the next module, we will build on this foundation to examine **animal rights frameworks**, including where welfare approaches may fall short and where rights-based arguments emerge.